Riding a crescendo of anti-incumbency against two-term chief minister K. Chandrashekar Rao and his party, the Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS), the Congress mounted an aggressive charge. The campaign, orchestrated by poll strategist and newly-appointed All India Congress Committee member Sunil Kanugolu, turned the seething disaffection against BRS MLAs, KCR and his family into a mass demand for change in rural Telangana. Before this deeply felt need, KCR's promises of new development schemes and the old, emotive chestnut of statehood stood little chance. Goaded by Kanugolu and led by the firebrand state unit chief Anumula Revanth Reddy, the Congress fearlessly implemented structural changes. Some veterans were sidelined, fresh local talent was sought out and brought in as candidates, and infighting was curbed with a firm hand. Buoyed by the Congress win in Karnataka in May, Reddy and Kanugolu replicated the model of campaigning there—twin focus on welfare via its 'six guarantees' and merciless skewering of an allegedly corrupt BRS regime. It gave them a mandate that Ashok Gehlot in Rajasthan and Kamal Nath in Madhya Pradesh were denied, primarily because they ignored the exhortations of the Congress national leadership to use Kanugolu's services. On December 7, Reddy was sworn in as the first Congress chief minister of Telangana.

The party reaped a rich harvest in Telangana, with its 39.48 per cent vote share a gain of 10 percentage points and its tally of 64 seats in the 119-member assembly—41 more than its electoral showing in 2018. However, the margin of its vote share vis-a-vis the BRS was a wafer-thin one, higher by just 2.09 percentage points, even if that slender margin was enough to

ENTHUSED BY THE CONGRESS WIN IN KARNATAKA, KANUGOLU AND REDDY ADOPTED THAT POLL MODEL WITH SPECTACULAR SUCCESS



Turnaround Man

A. Revanth Reddy, who delivered Telangana to the Congress, rejuvenated the party by taking the fight to the BRS

No sooner had it became clear on December 3 that the Congress was about to capture power in Telangana than state Congress chief A. Revanth Reddy announced that citizens have free access to the state secretariat, entry to which the outgoing CM K. Chandrashekar Rao had severely restricted. There is no doubt that Reddy, who is being credited for delivering Telangana to the Congress, has a swagger about his politics. This, combined with his decisive aggression, makes for an interesting political persona. When KCR declared he would contest from a second constituency, Kamareddy, Revanth decided to take KCR on, in addition to contesting from Kodangal. That both lost to a BJP newcomer is another story.

Ever since the 54-year-old firebrand took charge as Telangana PCC chief on July 7, 2021, at Rahul Gandhi's behest, he has infused youthful aggression into the Grand Old Party. Reddy joined the party in 2017 and was among the three Congress leaders elected to the Lok Sabha, from Malkajgiri constituency, in 2019. The Telangana Congress was in a bad shape at this juncture—in June 2019, 12 of its 19 MLAs defected to the ruling Telangana Rashtra Samithi, or TRS (as BRS was known then). Reddy, a relative newcomer, set about lifting the party's sagging morale, winning over disparate groups.

His critics have labeled him a 'party-hopper'. Starting off as an activist of the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad, the student wing of the RSS, Reddy's career took off after he joined the TRS in 2003. He quit it in 2005 after being denied a ticket for the 2004 assembly polls and, as an independent candidate, became a zilla parishad territorial committee member in 2006 and an MLC in 2007. Thereafter, he joined the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) and was elected as an MLA in 2009 and 2014 from Kodangal. When Telangana was born in 2014, Reddy was appointed the party's state unit chief. In 2015, the state's Anti-Corruption Bureau charged him with trying to buy votes in the Telangana Legislative Council polls. The case is still pending before the court. Meanwhile, judging TDP prospects in Telangana to be bleak, Reddy switched to the Congress. As their candidate, he lost in Kodangal in 2018; six months on, he won from Malkajgiri. Reddy's combativeness and vibrant presence on social media ensured the Congress was highly visible as a potent rival of the BRS. He upped his game after the Congress victory in Karnataka, and moulded the silent Congress wave that swept Telangana. He took part in 87 election rallies as TPCC chief.

Reddy hails from a farmer's family in Kalwakurthy, in Mahbubnagar district. A graduate in fine arts from AV College, Hyderabad, Reddy ran an advertising and printing agency before becoming a full-time politician. ■